Part 4: Tie-Breaking Essay

These notes are not intended to be understood as a key for the Tie-Breaking Essay prompt; rather, they should serve the judge(s) as a presentation of critical ideas that might appear in an essay responding to the prompt.

Criteria for judging the Tie-Breaking Essay **SHOULD** include

the degree to which the instructions have been followed,

the quality of the critical insight offered in response to the selection,

the overall effectiveness of the written discussion, and

the grammatical correctness of the essay.

Note well that the quality of the contestant's critical insight is more important than the contestant's prose style. In short, the Literary Criticism contest is one that promotes the critical analysis of literature. The quality of the writing, which should never go unappreciated, does not trump evidence of critical analysis.

Critical Notes on Emily Dickinson's "[As imperceptibly as grief]"

Literary concepts that MIGHT be used in a discussion of the effectiveness of Emily Dickinson's use of the simile in "[As imperceptibly as grief]" include

alliteration,
assonance,
imagery,
internal rhyme,
inversion,
oxymoron,
personification,
sigmatism,
synecdoche,
tenor,
tone, and
vehicle.

The contestant should recognize that each of the first three stanzas turns on a simile and that the final stanza serves to sum up the overall qualities of three of the poem's four vehicles (the comparison's immediate subject) as the summer's "light escape" (line 15), summer's exit—initially argued to be perfidious (4)—being the collective tenor (the poem's intentional subject). Something might be made of the positioning of each of the succeeding stanza's dominant similes: the first stanza begins with a simile; the second stanza's simile is found on that stanza's second line; the third stanza presents its simile on its final line. If this sequence is part of the student's observation, something should be noted regarding the positioning of the poem's tenor "summer['s making] her light escape" in its own, the poem's final, stanza.

The focus of a good response to the poem is the aggregate of the comparisons, which Dickinson, as speaker, draws through the poem. The first stanza finds an emotive aspect of summer's lapsing and presents it as grief: the summer is passive in this comparison. The second stanza shifts from an imperceptible lapsing to a process of distillation and sequestering (summer yet passive; overarching Nature as active). The third stanza colors the shift with anxiety, the simile suggesting a decidedly active summer (a "guest who would be gone").

Dickinson's synecdochical "without a wing, / Or service of a keel" (13-14) sustains the effortlessness, the stealthiness, and the quickness of summer's exit as suggested by the similes dominating the first three stanzas. The resolution of the poem's imagery and sentiment (15-16) [the first stanza's grief, the second stanza's isolation, and the third stanza's "harrowing grace" (11)],"[i]nto the beautiful," controls, finally, the tone of the poem.